

Some facts about Raja Manickam

1. He is named after his grandfather, Manickam. The first name Raja was given to him by his mother who never called her father-in-law by his name.
2. Raja completed primary education in India before studying up to eighth standard in Singapore, and then shifted back to India for secondary school and engineering degree.
3. He has served the Singapore armed forces and is a trained tank commander.
4. Raja Manickam has worked in sales, engineering, research, and many other verticals of the semiconductor ecosystem.
5. He could have done PhD with the help of a scholarship but started working after IIT Kharagpur to support his family.
6. Raja's father-in-law was the youngest minister in the Tamil Nadu cabinet in DMK government.
7. He took a loan against his house to fund Tessolve Semiconductors.

after his grandfather as per tradition those days.

Raja is the second eldest child in a family of five siblings. He recalls how tough the days were back then when he was a child as the finances to meet the family needs were always low. However, one lesson his grandfather always taught him was about the importance of education, and how it can change and revolutionise someone's life. Thanks to his grandfather and reformist movement in the sixties and seventies in Tamil Nadu, Raja was exposed to liberal thinking and was highly influenced by great statesman like Periyar, and Annadurai and Kamaraj who preached equality in community.

"My grandfather was not a highly educated person and probably that is why he understood the importance of being educated. He would always guide me during my childhood and encourage me to pursue the route of education more than anything else," recalls Raja. He adds, "It was all about education to him. He always made it clear to me that education would not just help me come out of poverty, but it would empower me to help the society as well."

Raja's mother, as he explains, was also a very big influence on him. Though she studied probably till the fifth or sixth standard only, she had leadership skills that brought the village people together. She encouraged all her children, five of them, to prioritise education. Each of them had a profession assigned to them.

The oldest, Raja's sister was to be a doctor, Raja was to be an engineer, the next one to be an accountant, and so on. That created a direction for the kids to work towards making their grandfather's and mother's dream come true. Raja enjoyed math and physics, which were directly relevant to engineering.

Raja's wife runs one of the biggest not-for-profit schools for the Tamil community in the US, and there are about 20,000 people attached to it. His grandfather was a part of the Self-Respect Movement and Dravidar Kazhagam. These movements were against the Brahmanical dominance and gender and caste inequality in Tamil Nadu.

Though Manickam family belonged to the upper caste, Raja's mother made sure that people from all the castes were able to go inside their Tamil Nadu home and interact with the family like one. "My grandfather, father, and all the other family members were against the caste system. I was also heavily influenced by their thought," explains Raja.

Battle tanks to IIT Kharagpur

Raja is the first graduate in family. He was undergoing primary education in India when his father showed interest in getting him educated back in Singapore. Raja went to Singapore for further schooling but as fate would have it, he returned to India after completing eighth standard from Singapore.

Always wanting to be among the top students wherever he was study-

ing, Raja drew inspiration from his fellow students and his elder sister to always excel in studies. He went to RSK Hr Sec School in BEHL in Trichy to complete his senior secondary, and was among the top students of the school. "My elder sister, Muthumanimoli, was always topping the school. I was heavily influenced by the way she was scoring top grades in school. Now a practicing doctor in the United States, I have always been inspired by what she has accomplished in life," shares Raja.

Not just studies, Raja also excelled at sports. He was a regular on basketball courts and hockey grounds. Unlike many children, who wish to watch cartoons or play video games, he would always head to play outdoor sports with his close friends. He represented his school in hockey, and IIT Kharagpur in hockey and basketball.

There's also a very interesting story about how he got into IIT Kharagpur. Before sharing that story Raja teasingly shares, "I was better balanced than my elder sister. She was a bookworm, and I excelled in sports as well as studies."

Raja had never aimed for getting into an IIT. He was aiming to secure an engineering seat in REC Trichy. However, Raja was a Singapore citizen, and the Singapore government requires every citizen to serve in the Singapore Military for a brief period of time, so when Raja turned eighteen, he had to return to his country of birth.

It was in the military that he came to know about the scholarship being offered to Singapore citizens by the government of India. The High Commission of India was working with the government of Singapore to find scholars for offering sponsorship to study. Raja applied for the same and appeared for the entrance exam at the High Commission office in Singapore. Only two scholars were picked and Raja was one of them.

"I wanted to pursue electronics engineering, and only IIT Kharagpur was offering engineering in electronics at that time. I would rate that as one of the best experiences of my life. IIT Kharagpur made me what I am today," says Raja.

He is thankful for the scholarship offered by the government of India,